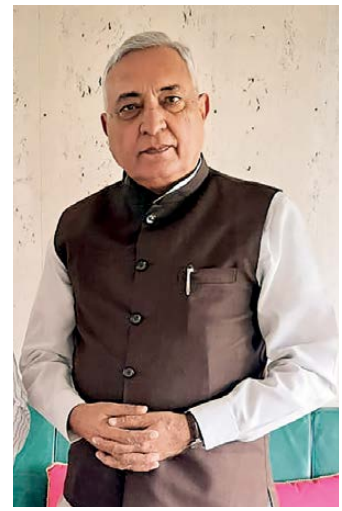
V. SOMANNA, *72*

| BJP | *Tumkur, Karnataka*

Now the Union minister of state for railways and Jal Shakti, this Lingayat leader started off as a corporator in Bengaluru in 1983. After long stints in the Janata Dal and the Congress, Somanna made a switch to the BJP in 2008. Having held various portfolios during the party's two terms in Karnataka, he challenged the Congress's Siddaramaiah from the latter's home turf Varuna in the state election last year. Siddaramaiah won and went on to reclaim the CM's chair. That failure notwithstanding, Somanna has staged a comeback by defeating former Congress MP S.P. Muddahanumegowda to enter the Lok Sabha from Tumkur.



DEVESH CHANDRA THAKUR, *71*

| JD(U) |

Sitamarhi, Bihar

A former chairperson of the Bihar Legislative Council, Thakur is a four-term MLC who has also served as a minister in the Nitish Kumar government. While studying law in Pune, he was elected as the Maharashtra Youth Congress vice-president. Known for having travelled extensively around the world, Thakur ran into controversy soon after he was elected to the Lok Sabha. The Brahmin leader said he would not entertain "personal" requests from Muslims and Yadavs as they did not vote for him though he would work for all communities. He later retracted the statement, calling it an "emotional outburst", but the damage had been done.



HINDUSTAN TIMES

RAMVIR SINGH BIDHURI, *71*

| BJP | *South Delhi, Delhi*

An old war horse in Delhi politics, Bidhuri's association with the saffron party goes back to 1970 when he joined its student wing ABVP while pursuing BA from Deshbandhu College, Delhi University. A four-term MLA, he represented Badarpur, a seat he had won for the first time in Delhi's maiden election in 1993. Among the eight BJP candidates who won the assembly election in 2020, Bidhuri was appointed the Opposition leader. In 2008, he was conferred with the 'Best MLA' award by then Speaker Somnath Chatterjee. With that illustrious career behind him, he now comes to the Lok Sabha, after putting AAP's Sahi Ram 'Pehalwan' on the mat.

-Rohit Parihar, Ajay Sukumaran, Kaushik Deka, Amitabh Srivastava and Avishek G. Dastidar